



connectivity from India has lagged for nearly two decades. Demand has consistently outpaced supply, leaving ample headroom for growth,” says Iyer.

He says the airline’s international strategy is guided by long-term vision and resource-conscious expansion. Hence, Akasa is looking to expand operations to Central Asia (Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan), Southeast Asia (Malaysia, Singapore, Thailand, and

Indonesia), South Asia (Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, and Nepal), and Africa (Tanzania, Egypt, and Kenya). It currently operates flights to several international destinations, including Kuwait, Abu Dhabi, and Riyadh.

“For international expansion, one key enabler will be the renegotiation of bilateral agreements between India and countries where entitlements are exhausted—such as in the Middle East and in the

ASEAN region,” says Iyer.

Dubey says one of Akasa’s biggest strengths is the huge order book as aviation airline is a business of scale. But aviation is inherently complex. “To succeed, airlines must be well-capitalised, have industry-leading cost structures, and professional management teams with large-scale experience. For Akasa, these are in place,” says Dubey.

He believes there are three pitfalls airlines must avoid: not being well-capitalised—every airline needs rainy-day funds; weak cost structures—if you can’t outrun competitors, you won’t survive; and, ignoring customers—service excellence and customer trust are the only sustainable drivers of long-term revenue growth. Dubey says the airline is well-capitalised and hasn’t outlined a plan for another round, expecting its initial public offering to take place within two to five years.

Akasa’s rise highlights broader shifts in India’s aviation sector. Analysts say there is room for challengers in a country with 1.4 billion people but fewer than 700 commercial aircraft. Still, the hurdles are formidable. Supply chain disruptions continue to slow aircraft deliveries. Structural costs—airport fees, fuel, etc—show little sign of easing. And profits remain elusive even as unit economics improve.

However, Akasa is in a better position than some of those who lost out. This is primarily due to the founding team, which consists of airline professionals with decades of experience, and improved infrastructure in the country, which includes more airports emerging in metros and a stable aviation policy.

As JetSetGo’s Tekriwal points out, the narrative is changing. “The old joke—that if you want to become a millionaire, start with a billion and launch an airline—may finally be losing relevance,” she says. **BT**